but holding some crucial posts including those of the project director of liquid propulsion and cryogenics. By explaining how the organisation and its people worked, I hoped, I could drive some sense into these gentlemen and show that such a spy case can only happen in the fertile imagination of some vested interests.

'How much of it is classified information?' one of the officers asked, about the drawings of rocket engines and other parts.

'Nothing,' I replied. 'Nothing in ISRO is classified or de-classified. Drawings and documents are there for any scientist to refer. Though there was no ban on taking out drawings, rarely did a scientist take them home.'

The CBI men asked sensible questions, and appeared to be—in stark contrast to my previous interrogators from IB—unprejudiced and receptive, even while keeping their trained scepticism intact. The interrogation went on from 7:30 pm on 5 December to 2:30 am the next day. I didn't have to think for half a minute before answering any of the questions—they were direct; and since I had nothing to hide, I elaborated on every point that I knew of.

At the end of it all, Vijayarama Rao took both my hands in his and said, 'We now have a clear picture. I don't know how this whole case has come to this stage. We are terribly sorry.'

I looked into his eyes for a moment, then broke down. I wept like a child for a couple of minutes. There was pin-drop silence in the room. When I regained my composure, Rao asked me to calm down, that justice would be delivered. He left the room saying, 'Ask our men whatever you want.' From that day, my handcuffs were gone.

After a few hours, in the morning, I asked for breakfast. Constable Subhash brought bread and omelette. He said now I was allowed to take visitors. The first one to visit me was my son. I inquired about my wife. My son was silent for a moment, then he spoke: 'She doesn't know what's happening.'

I didn't understand the gravity of that statement then; only later would I know that she, after witnessing my arrest, had gone silent and was sinking deeper into depression that would soon leave her deranged.